

Evan Coats

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LEADERSHIP & AI SAFETY COMMUNITY BUILDING

AI Alignment @ Illinois, Founder & Co-President (*Summer 2025 – Present*)

Affiliated student organization, Siebel School of Computing and Data Science, UIUC

- Founded and built UIUC's first dedicated AI alignment organization from a reading group, secured official affiliation with the Siebel School of Computing and Data Science and recruited a core team including Co-President Daniel Elliot.
- Run weekly reading groups covering foundational and frontier alignment research (e.g., interpretability, RLHF, scalable oversight), plus hands-on technical workshops introducing members to empirical alignment work.
- Built faculty and ecosystem relationships across UIUC CS and Philosophy to sustain long-term programming and connect members to research opportunities.

OPERATIONAL EXPERIENCE

Correlation Ventures, Machine Learning Intern (*Jun 2025 – Aug 2025*)

- Shipped end-to-end ML pipelines for startup outcome inference in a live investment setting; translated research ideas into production-ready systems under real deadlines.
- Presented quantitative findings and actionable next steps for an AI-as-investor methodology to firm leadership.

Carl R. Woese Institute for Genomic Biology, Researcher (*Jan 2024 – Present*)

Varshney Lab; NSF Expeditions "Mind in Vitro" project

- Co-author on a peer-reviewed paper in dynamical systems accepted for oral presentation at NYSDS '25 (SIAM Proceedings) and a preprint on simulation & modeling of in-vitro neural systems.

EDUCATION

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign (*Expected May 2027*)

M.S. in Computer Science (research-based) • Thesis advisor: Prof. Rainer Engelken

- Thesis focus: **dynamical interpretability and foundation models for neural data.**

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign (*Dec 2025*)

B.S. in Computer Science & Philosophy with High Distinction

- Relevant coursework: CS591 Biologically Plausible AI, CS446 Machine Learning, CS374 Algorithms, CS450 Numerical Analysis, ECE421 Neural Interface Engineering.

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

- **Evan Coats** and Lav R. Varshney. "Neural Network Memory Criticality: from Echo State to HiPPO and Beyond." Oral presentation, New York Scientific Data Summit 2025; SIAM Proceedings.
- Frithjof Gressmann, Ivan Georgiev Raikov, **Evan Coats**, Hau Ngoc Pham, Ivan Soltesz, and Lawrence Rauchwerger. "livn: A Testbed for Learning to Interact with In Vitro Neural Networks." Preprint, bioRxiv.

SKILLS & TOOLS

Organizing & leadership: club founding & operations, event programming, reading-group facilitation, community building, faculty relations, grant/fellowship applications.

Technical: PyTorch, JAX, Julia, TensorFlow, SciPy, agentic LLM systems, Python, Git, LaTeX.

Domains: AI alignment, interpretability, machine learning, computational neuroscience, philosophy of AI.